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BIG AI SHIFT IN GOVERNMENT SERVICES

■ 50% OF SECTORS, SERVICES AND OPERATIONS TO MOVE TO AI

■ PROCESS OF SHIFTING TO BE DONE WITHIN NEXT TWO YEARS

■ UAE TO BE FIRST TO ADOPT 'AGENTIC AI' MODELS GLOBALLY

DUBAI

BY KHITAM AL AMIR
Chief News Editor

The UAE will transform half of its government sectors, services and operations to autonomous artificial intelligence systems within two years, under the directives of President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan.

The major government shift was announced by His Highness Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, as he chaired the UAE Cabinet meeting yesterday.

Writing on his official X account, Sheikh Mohammed said: "The UAE will shift 50 per cent of government services to autonomous AI within two years."

Announcing what he described as a new government system, Sheikh Mohammed said the plan aims to make the UAE the first country globally to adopt "agentic AI" models capable of independently executing tasks, managing processes and supporting decision-making.

Executive partner

"Advanced AI systems can now monitor changes, provide analysis, issue recommendations and carry out sequences of actions without human intervention", the Vice-President said, adding that the technology would act as an executive partner to government, enhancing



DMO

■ Sheikh Mohammed and Sheikh Mansour during the Cabinet meeting yesterday.

efficiency, improving services and enabling real-time evaluation and optimisation.

Sheikh Mohammed said ministers, directors-general and federal entities would be assessed over the next two years based on their ability to keep pace with the transformation, including how quickly they implement new standards and adopt AI tools to reshape government operations.

He added that all federal government employees would undergo specialised training to

develop expertise in artificial intelligence, with the aim of equipping the workforce to lead what he described as one of the largest government transformation projects.

Sheikh Mansour Bin Zayed Al Nahyan, Vice-President, Deputy Prime Minister and Chairman of the Presidential Court, will oversee the implementation of the initiative, while a task force led by Mohammad Al Gergawi, Minister of UAE Cabinet Affairs, has been formed to follow up on execution.

Sheikh Mohammed said the transformation reflects rapid global technological change, adding that people would remain at the centre of government priorities, with the goal of creating an environment that enables individuals to realise their potential and improve quality of life.

The project includes a phased implementation across ministries and federal entities, based on continuous performance and impact assessment. This will pave the way for wider rollout,

ensuring optimal results across the federal government.

Digital transformation

The move to adopt Agentic AI across government operations builds on 20 years of digital transformation in the UAE's government, from the early adoption of eGovernment and service digitalisation to mobile government and integrated systems such as the UAE Pass identity verification system to full-service redesign and integration, supported by programmes such as Government Services 2.0, which introduced proactive, data driven service delivery.

During the meeting, the Cabinet approved a series of resolutions and projects to strengthen the government services ecosystem, including the adoption of the UAE Code for Government Services and Zero Bureaucracy. The Cabinet also approved the "government services digital records policy" to establish a national framework for managing government services data.

The Cabinet further approved a "government services data sharing policy" based on the principle of collecting data once and using it securely across entities. It approved the issuance of a "Federal government guide to aligning digital government projects with national priorities". The Cabinet also approved a series of strategic initiatives to strengthen competitiveness, sustainability, and international cooperation.

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SPECIAL REPORT | LIMITLESS



LEADERSHIP IN TIMES OF CHANGE

At Tristar's and Gulf News' Limitless: The UAE Power Women's Forum, leaders from across sectors shared insights on leadership and resilience amid regional disruption and shifting priorities to a packed audience | P8-9

Trump escalates Hormuz crisis with 'shoot and kill' order

Iran claims first tolls as shipping choked and global oil route turns into leverage

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

US President Donald Trump has ordered the military to "shoot and kill" Iranian boats laying mines in the Strait of Hormuz, sharply escalating tensions as the strategic waterway remains effectively choked by a worsening US-Iran standoff.

"I have ordered the United States Navy to shoot and kill any boat... that is putting mines in the waters of the Strait of Hormuz," Trump said in a social media post, adding that mine-clearing operations were being intensified "at a tripled up level."

Different reality

Trump has turned to naval blockades to pressure the governments of Venezuela, Cuba and now Iran to meet his demands, but his preferred tactic is confronting a very different reality in the Middle East than in the Caribbean.

The order came as Iran signalled it would keep the strait restricted to a limited number

● **Adding to tensions, the US military said it seized another tanker, the Majestic X, in the Indian Ocean, accusing it of being part of Iran's oil-smuggling network.**

of approved vessels, linking any reopening to an end to the US naval blockade on its ports.

The confrontation has crippled one of the world's most critical oil routes. Shipping traffic has plunged, with vessels turning away amid rising insurance costs and fears of attack.

Adding to tensions, the US military said it seized another tanker, the Majestic X, in the Indian Ocean, accusing it of being part of Iran's oil-smuggling network. The move followed Iran's interception of vessels in Hormuz, including forcing ships toward its coast.

At the same time, Tehran claims it has begun collecting tolls from ships crossing the strait — a move widely seen as violating international maritime norms and further raising the stakes.

Iran's parliament speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, who has taken a leading role

in negotiations, said reopening the strait was "not possible" while the US blockade continues, calling it a "blatant violation" of the ceasefire.

Economic fallout

Despite a fragile truce, the economic fallout is intensifying. Oil prices have climbed, airlines have cancelled flights, and business activity in Europe has shown signs of contraction amid uncertainty tied to the Gulf crisis.

Shipping groups warn that a "stable ceasefire and assurances" from both sides are needed before vessels can safely resume transit. Mine-clearing could take months, with some estimates suggesting up to six months.

Talks in Islamabad are still on the table but uncertain, with Iran yet to confirm participation and US Vice-President JD Vance postponing his visit.

Analysts say both sides are betting on economic pain to force concessions — Iran by restricting a vital energy route, and the US by targeting Tehran's oil exports.

For now, the Strait of Hormuz — a lifeline of global energy — has become the central battleground in a high-stakes confrontation with no clear end in sight.

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UAE banks post strong profits

DUBAI

BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor

UAE banks reported strong first-quarter earnings, underpinned by lending growth and diversified income, while flagging the impact of regional tensions on market activity.

First Abu Dhabi Bank posted net profit of Dh5.01 billion, saying it operated "through a period of heightened regional tensions and market volatility," with "dampened client flows towards the end of the quarter," though disruption remained limited.

Emirates NBD reported record income of Dh14.4 billion and said it entered "this period of heightened geopolitical uncertainty from a position of strength," supported by robust capital and liquidity buffers.

Abu Dhabi Commercial Bank posted a 30 per cent rise in profit before tax to Dh3.78 billion, while taking provisions "to address heightened geopolitical risks" amid the external environment. Across the sector, strong balance sheets and policy support helped lenders sustain growth despite volatility.

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